

ENGLISH FOR ALL DISCIPLINES



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English for All Disciplines

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Detailed Licensing

Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

1: Introduction

What will we learn in this chapter?

In this chapter, you will learn language patterns and U.S. academic customs to help you succeed in all your college courses and in your life as a U.S. college student.



Figure 1.1: College students studying together. (CC-0 by RDNE Stock Project via Pexels)

Essential Questions

Ask yourself these questions, or discuss them with a friend, relative, teacher, or classmate. The material in this chapter can add to your answers.

- How are the cultural customs of U.S. colleges the same or different from the academic cultures I've experienced before, in my home country, another country, or in high school?
- Where can I find help at my college, with my classes or with other questions or problems?
- What vocabulary and strategies can I use
 - to understand readings and lectures in English?
 - to listen and talk in group work and class discussions?
 - to participate in online activities?
 - to take tests and write papers?

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2: Navigating U.S. College Culture

What should new U.S. college students know?

As an international or immigrant student, navigating the U.S. college campus culture can be an exciting and sometimes overwhelming experience.

Here are some essential tips and insights to help you adapt to and thrive in the college environment:

Embrace diversity

U.S. college campuses are known for their rich diversity. Be open to meeting people from various backgrounds and cultures. Engage in multicultural events, join international student organizations, and participate in campus activities to broaden your horizons and build meaningful connections.

Understand academic expectations

Familiarize yourself with the academic expectations and grading system at your college. Attend orientations and workshops, and utilize support services like academic advising to understand the requirements of your program and develop effective study strategies.

Grades

Many, but not all, U.S. colleges use this standard grading system based on the percentage of possible points you earn in a class:

- A = 90-100% = 4 points for your Grade Point Average (GPA)
- B = 80-89% = 3 points for your GPA
- C = 70-79% = 2 points for your GPA
- D = 60- 69% = 1 point for your GPA (not passing, but may count for some purposes)
- F = below 60% (not passing)
- W = withdraw (you started the class but dropped it)
- I = incomplete (you finished most of the class, but something happened that kept you from finishing, so you have a contract with the instructor to finish the last bit after the semester ends)

Some colleges also offer the option of a pass/fail or credit/noncredit grade, which usually means that you will earn a pass for any score at or above 70% of the possible points. Choosing this option can take the pressure off your performance. However, this choice might affect your GPA, visa status, financial aid, or transfer eligibility, so check with a counselor or advisor before choosing this option.

Attendance

In U.S. colleges, you are expected to attend every class session and arrive on time. Most instructors take attendance and expect you to email them if you are going to miss a class or arrive late. Colleges often have a policy that if you miss a certain number of class sessions, you can be dropped from the class.

Homework

Most college classes require homework. As a general rule, you can expect to do two hours of homework each week for every one hour the class meets each week.

Engage in classroom discussions

Active participation in classroom discussions is highly encouraged in the U.S. Share your thoughts, ask questions, and engage in respectful debates. This not only enhances your learning experience but also helps you build relationships with professors and classmates. You might feel nervous at first, but you will soon feel more confident. It's fine if your English is not perfect because your classmates and professor want to hear your voice!

Seek support services

U.S. colleges offer various support services to help students succeed. Visit the international student office for immigration-related guidance, cultural adjustment support, and information on campus resources. Additionally, utilize academic support centers, writing centers, and counseling services for assistance tailored to your needs.

Understand campus policies and norms

Familiarize yourself with campus policies, rules, and regulations. Respect cultural norms, academic integrity standards, and codes of conduct. Adhere to deadlines, attend mandatory orientations, and be aware of campus safety measures.

Build a support network

Create a support network by connecting with other international and domestic students. Seek out mentors, join student clubs, and participate in extracurricular activities to build friendships and a sense of belonging. This network can provide emotional support and cultural exchange, and help you navigate challenges.

Practice time management and self-care

Managing your time effectively is crucial. Create a schedule, prioritize tasks, and allocate time for studying, socializing, and self-care. Balancing academics with leisure activities and taking care of your physical and mental well-being are essential for success.

Celebrate your culture

Share your unique cultural heritage with others. Organize cultural events, participate in international festivals, and engage in intercultural dialogues to promote cultural exchange and foster a sense of community.

Stay curious and flexible

Approach your college experience with an open mind, curiosity, and a willingness to adapt. Embrace new challenges, learn from different perspectives, and be open to personal growth.

Check your understanding of U.S. college culture

? Exercise 2.1

Add exercises text here.

Answer

Add texts here. Do not delete this text first.

? Try this!

1. If you are taking a class that meets for 2 hours each Tuesday and Thursday, how many hours should you set aside for homework for that class during each week?

Click here to see the answer

At least 8 hours (4 class hours x 2)

2. If you get 87% of the possible points in a class by the end of the semester, how will that class grade affect your GPA?

Click here to see the answer

You will get a B, which counts for 3 points in your Grade Point Average.

3. Is the best way to succeed in college to stay alone studying every minute you are not in class?

Click here to see the answer

No! Participating in fun activities and self-care are also important to your English fluency and college success.

Find out more about your own college

Apply this!

Look at your college catalog or website, and the syllabi from each of your classes.

1. What clubs meet on your campus that you might like to join?
2. What tutoring and academic advising services does your college offer?
3. Do your professors all have the same grading policies?
4. What is an upcoming event you could attend to meet other students with common interests?

Remember, your college years are not just about academics but also about personal growth and cultural exploration. Embrace the opportunities and challenges that come your way, and make the most of your college experience.

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3: Communicating with Classmates and Professors

How can I effectively communicate with classmates and professors?

Many communication norms are universal: no matter where you go to college, you already know it's important to respect cultural differences and be mindful of diverse perspectives in the classroom. Students everywhere are expected to use polite language, avoid interrupting others, and wait for their turn to speak. Part of participating in college is treating your classmates and professors with respect, even if you disagree with their opinions. However, a few U.S. customs might be slightly different from your previous academic experiences.



Figure 3.1: "Positive multiethnic students celebrating success in project with teacher." by Kampus Production from Pexels. CC-0)

In the classroom

You will probably be expected and even required as part of your grades to contribute to small-group and whole-class discussions, sharing your opinions and ideas, not just repeating facts. You also need to listen carefully to your classmates and connect what you are saying to what has already been said. You may also need to disagree respectfully. U.S. college culture is known for being very interactive, and some of your classes are likely to feel more like the situation in Figure 2.3.1 than one with the professor lecturing to students.

Trusting your voice

Professors and classmates expect you to speak like you are in a conversation, rather than reciting something you've memorized or reading from your notes. It is fine to make a few grammatical or pronunciation mistakes; the most important thing is that people can understand your ideas. When you are speaking to the whole class, remember that you are not only speaking to the professor; find the person farthest away from you in the classroom and pretend you are talking to them, so your voice

will be loud enough. Emphasize keywords and pause after important points so your listeners catch your meaning.

This may vary by situation, but in a small class, students can usually ask questions at any time during the class, or at least between activities, so you don't need to wait until the end. Most professors will not see this as a rude interruption, but rather as a polite sign of engagement and dedication to learning. If you are in a small group, it's often expected that you will ask other students your question before you ask the professor.

Body language

Students often raise their hands to be called on, but in some classes, students may talk without being called on. It's rare in the U.S. to stand up before speaking, unless you are giving a presentation from the front of the class. As in other U.S. English situations, eye contact is considered respectful, even to elders. If eye contact is uncomfortable for you, here's a trick: try focusing on the other person's forehead. When speaking to a group, find a friendly face in each section of the room and move your eyes between those people.

As far as personal space, according to an article from [The Leaf Project](#), U.S. English speakers need at least one meter (about three feet) of space between people to feel comfortable. The U.S. ranked 13th out of 42 countries in a 2017 study published in the [Journal of Cross-Cultural Psychology](#), measuring how close people can stand to each other in casual situations and still feel comfortable. This puts the average U.S. distance between speakers closer than speakers from many countries, such as Saudi Arabia, Colombia, and China, but farther away than speakers from countries such as Argentina, Peru, and Ukraine.

See: [2.7: Participating in Class Discussions](#) for useful language.

Outside the classroom

Most professors hold office hours in their office, in the classroom, or in another space on campus. Office hours are regular times when professors are available to help students. Try to visit each of your professors early in the semester to say hello and ask a question, even if you are not having a problem. You are not bothering them! It's part of their job to see students outside of class, and they will remember you better and see that you are interested and engaged. Many U.S. students form study groups to work together outside of class. This is a great way to make friends and improve your English!

Emailing a professor

Most professors (unless it's a large lecture course) expect you to email them in these situations:

- you are going to miss or be late to class
- you have a disability that needs accommodation
- you are having trouble with assignments
- you plan to drop the class
- you have any other kind of problem or question about the class

Use your official student email or the course messaging system, or at least an email address that sounds professional (not something like iheartpizzalol@hotmail.com). You can typically expect a response within 1-2 days, except on weekends and holidays. That means if you email your professor on Friday evening, expect a reply by Monday or Tuesday evening. You should:

- Tell the professor your full name and the class because they may have other students with your same first name, or other sections of the same class you are in ("This is xxxx xxxx from your T/Th morning COMM 52 class").
- Make the subject line say exactly what you are writing about, e.g. "Question about 2nd draft revision of paper #3", not something like "homework" or "I have a question".
- Start a new email for a new topic. Don't reply to a thread or class announcement about something else.
- Some professors are very casual with email and will even write back to you in "text speak." However, some are quite formal and will take offense if you do not carefully edit your email as if you are writing a polished paper.

Compare these example emails to professors

Notice this!

Compare these three emails for three different situations. Which elements are the same, and which are different? You can use these patterns as a template for writing your own emails to professors.

1.

Subject: Firstname Lastname absence Wednesday, October 4

Dear Professor X,

This is Firstname Lastname from your MW GEOG 50 class. I am sorry that I have to miss class tomorrow because [I am not feeling well/I have a family emergency/my child is home sick/a sudden work situation came up that I need to take care of/etc.] I will check [Canvas/the class website] and ask...[name of classmate] if I need help with assignments and other class information.

Thanks in advance for your consideration.

Name _____

2.

Subject: Firstname Lastname office hours appointment?

Dear Professor X,

This is Firstname Lastname from your MW GEOG 50 class. I saw in the syllabus that you have office hours on Wednesdays from 2-3 pm. I have a question about this week's assignment. Should I just stop by room 326 anytime during that hour, or should I make an appointment? If so, can I arrive at 2:30?

Thanks for your advice.

Name _____

3.

Subject: Firstname Lastname extension request

Dear Professor X,

This is Firstname Lastname from your MW GEOG 50 class. I am writing to respectfully request an extension on the final draft of Research Paper #2. My progress was delayed when my family was sick last week, and I would like to work more on the paper in the tutoring center before I turn it in. May I please have a few more days? I apologize for the inconvenience.

Thanks in advance for your consideration.

Name _____

Check your knowledge

? Try this!

1. What should you do if you have a question in a small group activity?

- A. Shout out your question
- B. Raise your hand
- C. Keep your question to yourself
- D. Ask group members before asking the professor

Click here to see the answer

D. Ask group members before asking the professor

2. When is a good time to visit your professors during their office hours?

- A. Early in the semester
- B. At the end of the semester
- C. Only when I have a question
- D. Never

Click here to see the answer

A. Early in the semester

3. What do you think is considered a respectful way to express disagreement in class discussions?

- A. Interrupting the speaker to state your opinion
- B. Listening carefully and then respectfully sharing your differing viewpoint
- C. Ignoring the speaker's point and changing the subject

Click here to see the answer

B. Listening carefully and then respectfully sharing your differing viewpoint.

See [2.7: Participating in Class Discussions](#) for language suggestions for disagreeing.

www.leaflanguages.org/folium-what-personal-space-means-to-the-rest-of-world-via-lifehacker/. Licensed under [CC-BY-NC 4.0 International](#).

Sorokowska, Agnieszka, et al. "Preferred Interpersonal Distances: A Global Comparison." *Journal of Cross-Cultural Psychology*, vol. 48, no. 4, Mar. 2017, pp. 577–92, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0022022117698039>.

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Now use these skills

Apply this!

1. Find out when one of your professors has an office hour at a time you can attend, and draft an email to set up a meeting. Make sure to include your full name, class, and a specific subject line. Then go visit them!
2. Talk to a classmate who has lived in a different country from you about personal space customs (proxemics). Look at Figure 2.3.2 together, and discuss: what country do you think these measurements are based on? Are they similar in your home countries?

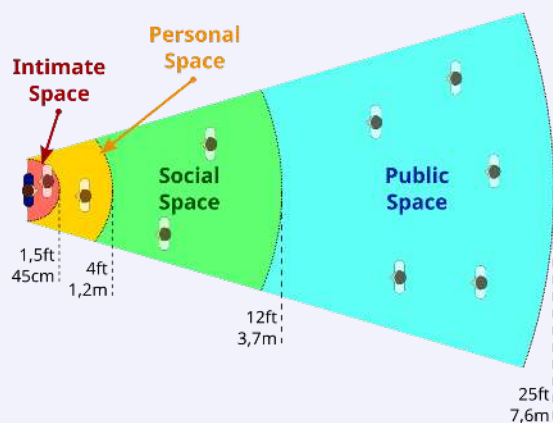


Figure 3.1: "Personal Spaces in Proxemics." [CC BY-SA 3.0](#). Jean-Louis Grall via Wikimedia Commons)

Works Cited

"Folium: What 'Personal Space' Means to the Rest of World via Lifehacker" *The LEAF Project*, 8 July 2020,

4: Finding Help

Campus Support Services

In this section, you will learn about different college support offices and the services they provide. By understanding these services, you will have a better grasp of how each office can help you and of the specific terms associated with them. This knowledge will help you navigate and utilize these resources effectively.

Note: Different campuses may have slightly different names or abbreviations for these services (e.g. your college might call the place you get help with enrollment the *Registrar*, and another college might call it *Admissions and Records*).



Figure 4.1:
Maynooth University Library - Staff. By
via [B20180](#) via Wikimedia Commons, Licensed under [Creative Commons Attribution-Share Alike 4.0 International](#).

Your school is full of friendly people like the librarians in Figure 2.4.1 who want to help you succeed.

Financial Aid Office

assists students in getting financial support for their education.

- **FAFSA (Free Application for Federal Student Aid):** This is a form that students must fill out to determine their eligibility for federal financial aid, such as grants, work-study programs, and student loans.
- **Grants:** Financial aid that does not need to be repaid, typically awarded based on financial need.
- **Scholarships:** Financial awards given to students based on various criteria, such as academic achievement, extracurricular involvement, or specific talents. You do not need to pay them back. See if your college offers scholarships you might qualify for! You usually have to apply for these, and you might need to write an essay or ask for a letter of recommendation. Here is a list of scholarships that undocumented students can apply for: [Immigrants Rising List of Scholarships and Fellowships](#).
- **Student Loans:** Borrowed money that must be repaid with interest, often offered at lower interest rates than private loans.

- **Vouchers:** Tickets or coupons you can exchange for books, supplies, transportation, etc.

Counseling Services

offer personal and academic support to students.

- **Personal Counseling:** Provides support for mental health and emotional well-being, addressing issues such as stress, anxiety, depression, relationships, and personal growth.
- **Academic Counseling:** Assists students with course selection, academic planning, goal setting, and overcoming academic challenges.

Disability Services

provide accommodations and support for students with disabilities.

- **Accommodations:** Adjustments made to ensure equal access to education for students with disabilities. Examples include extended time for exams, note-taking assistance, accessible materials, or physical accommodations like ramps or elevators.
- **Alternate Media:** Adapted forms of textbooks and other course materials, like braille, large-text, or digital versions that work with a screen reader or other program.
- **Test Proctoring:** Most accessibility offices have a special place where you can take tests with a staff member supervising, with extra time and fewer distractions than in your regular classes.

Library Services

a hub of knowledge and support with academic resources and study spaces.

- **Resources:** Provides access to a wide range of books, journals, articles, and other materials for academic research and leisure reading.
- **Study Spaces:** Offers quiet areas and group study rooms for students to study, collaborate, and engage in academic activities.
- **Librarians:** Trained professionals who can assist students with research strategies, finding relevant resources, and navigating databases.
- **Technology:** Provides computers, printers, scanners, and other equipment for student use.
- **Workshops/Tutoring:** Offers workshops and training sessions on research skills, information literacy, citation styles, and other library-related topics.

Information Technology (IT) Services

helps with technology-related issues on campus.

- **Login Problems:** Assist with trouble logging into class websites or other online platforms.
- **Technical Support:** Troubleshoot computer-related issues, software installations, and network problems.

Registrar's Office

handles various administrative tasks related to your academic journey.

- **Adding/Dropping a Class:** The office can provide information on the deadlines and procedures for adding/dropping a class.
- **Transcripts:** The office can assist with transcript requests and official documentation.

Additional Support Services

There are various additional support services available on campus. Here are some examples:

- Parenting and Veterans Support
- Community Resources (food bank, basic needs center, etc.)
- Undocumented Student Center
- Career and Transfer Center
- LGBTQIA Center
- Student Clubs
- Student Government and Leadership
- Student Ambassadors or Mentors
- Health and Wellness Center

Useful Language Patterns for Getting Help

Here are some examples of ways to ask for what you need:

- Can you explain the resources available for students with disabilities?
- I'm looking for internship opportunities. Can you tell me where to start?
- I'm having trouble with my coursework. Can you tell me how and where to find tutoring services?
- I'm confused about this website. Would you mind looking at it with me?
- Can you help me understand my options for financial aid?
- The person at [another office] suggested that I ask you about...

Check your knowledge

? Try this!

1. Where should I go if I need help paying for college?

- A. Financial Aid Office
- B. Counseling Center
- C. Disability Services Office

Click here to see the answer

- A. Financial Aid Office

2. Who should I ask if I am having trouble finding sources for a research paper?

- A. IT Services
- B. Library Services
- C. Disability Services Office

Click here to see the answer

- B. Library Services

Now use these skills

Apply this!

On your own or with a classmate, find the answers to these questions for your school:

- How do I make a counseling appointment?
- Who do I ask if I'm having login problems with the class website?
- How long do I have to drop a class if I realize it's not the class I want?
- Is there a food bank at our school or in the community?
- Where is the office that can help me get an accommodation plan if I have a learning disability?
- Are there programs at our school to help students who are parents, veterans, etc.?

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5: Listening to Lectures and Taking Notes

Why do we need to take notes?

Taking effective notes is a crucial skill for academic success. Even in modern classrooms that use technology and interactive learning, you will still likely need to listen to a professor, guest speaker, or classmate talking and write down the important ideas you hear. On this page you will learn some strategies to enhance your note-taking abilities: practicing active listening; noticing verbal cues, keywords, and nonverbal cues; checking your comprehension; and annotating your notes. You will also learn how to use the Cornell Method, a popular technique for taking notes that puts it all together.

Active Listening

Active listening is essential for effective note-taking. Here are some strategies:

- **Focus Fully:** Eliminate distractions and concentrate on the speaker. Put your phone away and straighten up any papers on your desk. This helps you absorb the material better.
- **Paraphrase:** Summarize what the speaker is saying in your own words. This reinforces your understanding and helps you remember the information. It also helps you avoid accidental plagiarism if you use your notes later to write a class assignment.
- **Engage with the Speaker and Material:** Nod, ask questions, and provide feedback to show you are engaged. This can enhance your understanding and retention, as well as communicating to the instructor that you are listening.

Notice this!

American Cultural Customs for Listeners

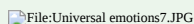


Figure 5.1: 7 universal facial expressions of emotions by PhD.Paul Ekman. (Icerko Lýdia, CC-BY 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)

- **Facial Expressions-** Many U.S. instructors will notice the faces of their students and expect to see an interested and engaged facial expression. If you look very serious, you might be just innocently concentrating, but they might interpret your face as angry, bored, or confused. Which of the facial expressions shown in Figure 2.5.1 do you think you should avoid making during a lecture in a U.S. classroom?
- **Eye Contact-** In American culture, maintaining direct eye contact indicates active listening, attentiveness, and respect. In some cultures, closing your eyes shows that you are listening deeply and respectfully, but some

American instructors may consider it rude for listeners to close their eyes for more than a second or two, as they consider eye contact a sign that you are paying attention. Even while taking notes, try to look up every minute or so. If direct eye contact is uncomfortable or impossible for you, it's OK to turn your face toward the speaker and look at their forehead, or look at the board or screen if they are using visual aids.

- **Nodding-** Nodding your head up and down is a common way to signal that you are listening and understanding the speaker.
- **Verbal Affirmations-** Using verbal affirmations is a way to verbally indicate that you are listening and following along, especially in a small group situation. Examples: uh-huh, mm-hmm, oh! wow! I see, go on. In a large lecture, it is customary to keep quiet.
- **Posture-** An open and attentive posture with uncrossed arms shows that you are attentive and receptive to the speaker.

Noticing verbal cues and keywords

- **Verbal cues:** Sometimes called "signal words/phrases" or "transitions," these words and phrases help listeners follow the structure of a lecture and identify important points and how they are connected.
- **Keywords:** It is important to listen for keywords and phrases that capture the main ideas, key concepts, and supporting examples. These keywords can help you identify the most important points in a lecture and structure your notes effectively. Usually keywords are repeated in the lecture.

Table 2.5.1 gives some examples of these important words to listen for:

Type of verbal cue	Examples
Introductory remarks: Pay attention to summaries or overviews of the main points given at the beginning of the lecture.	• Today, we will discuss the four main causes of... • Let me start by saying a few words about... • As you can see on the screen, our topic today is..... • This morning/afternoon I'm going to take a look at the recent developments in.....
Signal words/phrases: Listen for phrases that indicate the speaker is about to tell you an important point, review what they already said, present a different perspective, or predict the structure or purpose of the next part of the lecture.	• There are four main... • A major reason, • One example, • Of course, not everyone agrees that... • Let's take a look at one more... • So far we talked about... • To sum up, • To summarize, • Overall, • In conclusion,
Repeated words or concepts: If a word or concept is repeated multiple times, it is likely to be an important keyword to write down and look up later if you don't already know it.	• An English instructor might repeatedly mention "controlling ideas" when discussing organization in an essay. • A sociology instructor might repeat "disparities" when discussing the impact of an event on different groups of people. • A physics instructor might repeat "frequency" when discussing the characteristics of waves.

Noticing Nonverbal Cues

Nonverbal cues can significantly enhance your understanding during lectures. Pay attention to:

- **The instructor's body language:** Notice gestures, facial expressions, and posture. These can indicate the importance of certain points. For example, if an instructor glances at their notes and then makes a point, it is probably a signal that the information is especially important. Anything they read from their notes is a potential test question. If they walk to another place in the room, it may indicate an important shift in the topic.

- **Visual aids:** Charts, graphs, and slides often highlight key information. Make sure to include these in your notes. Copy all diagrams and drawings, equations, names, places, dates, statistics, and definitions that the speaker writes on the board or includes in a slide presentation.
- **Changes in tone:** A shift in the instructor's voice can signal a transition to a critical topic or a summary. Do they ask a question? Does their voice suddenly get serious? Do they slow down or repeat a phrase to emphasize its importance?

Checking your comprehension

The whole point of note-taking is to help you remember and understand the material. Here are some strategies to improve comprehension:

- **Summarize:** After each section of a lecture, take a moment to summarize what you've learned in your own words. This reinforces your understanding and helps you retain the information better.
- **Ask questions:** If something is unclear, jot down questions during the lecture. Seek clarification from the lecturer or classmates afterward. This active engagement helps deepen your understanding. In many U.S. classrooms, students will often raise a hand to interrupt the instructor with a question, and the instructor likes it - they see it as a sign that you are paying attention. In other situations, they expect you to wait until the end of a section, a slide, or the whole lecture. Notice the classroom culture for each situation, or ask a friendly classmate if you aren't sure. Example Questions:
 - "Can you clarify the difference between these two concepts?"
 - "I know you explained this part, but I'm still a little unclear about..."
 - "Could you provide an example to illustrate this point?"
 - "How does this concept relate to what we discussed in the last class?"

Annotating your notes

Annotating your notes can significantly enhance their effectiveness. Here's how to do it:

- **Highlight Key Points:** Use different colors or symbols to emphasize important concepts. This makes it easier to review later.
- **Add Examples:** Include relevant examples or personal experiences that relate to the material. This not only aids memory but also makes the notes more meaningful.
- **Use Diagrams and Visuals:** Incorporate diagrams, charts, or illustrations to represent complex ideas visually. This can help in understanding and recalling information.

Using the Cornell Method

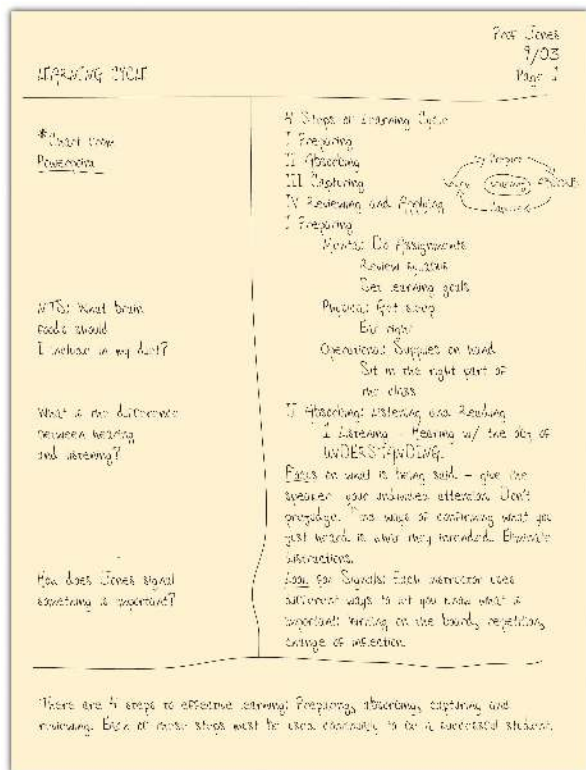


Figure 5.1: *The Cornell Method of Note Taking* (CC-BY-SA 3.0 section 4.4 from the book [Success in College](#) v. 1.0)

One way to organize your notes is a note-taking system that has worked for students around the world, the **Cornell Method** (Pauk and Owens 2011). Originally developed by Walter Pauk at Cornell University during the 1950s, this approach continues to be taught across the United States and in other countries as well. The cornerstone of this method is what Pauk calls the *cue column*—a wide margin on the left side of the paper. The cue column is the key to the Cornell method’s many benefits. Here’s how to use it:

- **Format your paper.** On each sheet, draw a vertical line from top to bottom about 2 inches from the left edge of the paper (see the example in Figure 2.5.2). This line creates the cue column—the space to the left of the line. You can also download this template or copy it onto a GoogleDoc: [Cornell Notes Instructions and Template.docx](#)
- **Take notes, leaving the cue column blank.** As you read an assignment or listen to a lecture, take notes on the right side of the paper. Fill up this column with sentences, paragraphs, outlines, charts, or drawings. Do not write in the cue column. You’ll use this space later, as you do the next steps.
- **Condense your notes in the cue column.** Think of the notes you took on the right side of the paper as a set of answers. In the cue column, list potential test questions that correspond

to your notes. Write one question for each major term or point.

- As an alternative to questions, you can list **keywords** from your notes. Another option is to pretend that your notes are a series of articles on different topics. In the cue column, write a **newspaper-style headline** for each “article.” In any case, be brief. Cramming the cue column full of words defeats its purpose—to reduce the number and length of your notes.
- **Write a summary.** Pauk recommends reducing your notes even more by writing a brief summary at the bottom of each page. This step offers you another way to engage actively with the material.
- **Use the cue column to recite.** Cover the right side of your notes with a blank sheet of paper. Leave only the cue column showing. Then, look at each item you wrote in the cue column and talk about it. If you wrote questions, answer each question. If you wrote key words, define each word and talk about why it’s important. If you wrote headlines in the cue column, explain what each one means and offer supporting details. After reciting, uncover your notes and look for any important points you missed.

Note

Technology Tools for Note-Taking

Utilizing technology can streamline the note-taking process. Here are some tools to consider:

- **Digital Note-Taking Apps:** Explore apps like Microsoft OneNote or Google Docs for organizing and sharing notes. These platforms allow for easy editing and collaboration.
- **Annotation Tools:** Use tools like Google Slides for visual presentations. These can enhance your notes with interactive elements.

Before you use a digital tool though, consider that some scientific studies suggest that writing with a pen or pencil on paper might help you learn better! For example, researchers Umejima et al. from the University of Tokyo tested how much university students retained an hour after taking notes on a lecture, and published their results in this article: “[Paper Notebooks vs. Mobile Devices: Brain Activation Differences During Memory Retrieval](#).” What do you predict they found?

Check your knowledge

? Try this!

1. What is one way to engage in active listening during a lecture?

- A. Texting friends
- B. Nodding and asking questions
- C. Daydreaming

Click here to see the answer

- B. Nodding and asking questions

2. Why is summarizing important in note-taking?

- A. It helps reinforce understanding
- B. It takes too much time
- C. It makes notes look neat

Click here to see the answer

- A. It helps reinforce understanding

3. What is a benefit of using technology for note-taking?

- A. It can lead to confusion
- B. It can streamline the process
- C. It is less effective

Click here to see the answer

- B. It can streamline the process

Now use these skills

Apply this!

Works Cited

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Treasure, Julian. "5 Ways to Listen Better." *Ted.com*, TED Talks, July 2011, www.ted.com/talks/julian_treasure_5_ways_to_listen_better.

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6: Reading Strategies for Academic Texts

What are academic texts, and how can we read them better?

Academic texts include textbooks, but also journal and magazine articles, technical reports, book reviews, and other genres. They are usually written by people who are experts in their subjects. Academic texts are usually less personal and more formal than other types of writing. They often include specialized vocabulary and complex sentence structures. They also assume a high level of background knowledge, so they can be difficult to read if you do not already know a lot about the topic. Reading academic texts can be challenging, but with the right strategies, you can improve your comprehension and efficiency. This section provides a few helpful strategies, summarized in Figure 2.6.1, to use before, during, and after you read.



Figure 6.1: Adapted from "The Basics of the PSQ3R Method" Rachael M. Benavidez, via [Active Reading and Annotation – College Writing](#) CC-BY-NC-SA 4.0

Before reading

Before you start actually reading, it's important to set up your mind to effectively take in the information. This will save you time in the long run.

Establishing your purpose for reading

Establishing *why* you read something helps you decide *how* to read it, which saves time and improves comprehension. In college and in your profession, you will read a variety of texts to gain and use information (e.g., scholarly articles, textbooks, reviews). Some purposes for reading might include the following:

- to skim to get an overview of the text
- to decide if the text will be useful to you as a source for research
- to learn the content for a test or project, or to use to make a decision
- to scan for specific information, such as evidence for an argument or counterargument
- to relate new content to existing knowledge
- to write a summary and/or response essay, journal, or online discussion contribution
- to discuss in class
- to critique an argument

- for general comprehension (e.g. on a TOEFL test)

Identifying the rhetorical context of a text

Understanding the rhetorical context means identifying the **purpose**, **author**, and **audience** of a text. This helps you understand why the text was written and how to approach it.

- **Purpose:** Why did the author write this? (e.g., to inform, persuade, or entertain)
- **Author:** Who wrote this? What is their background or expertise?
- **Audience:** Who is the text written for? (e.g., students, professionals, general readers)

Example:

If you're reading a science textbook chapter on climate change, the purpose is likely to inform, the author might be a scientist or educator, and the audience is students learning about the topic.

Before reading, ask yourself:

- What is the purpose of this text?
- Who wrote it, and why should I trust them?
- Who is the intended audience?

Surveying/Previewing

Surveying, also called previewing, means looking over the text before reading it in detail. This helps you get a sense of the structure and main ideas. Previewing is a powerful strategy to get an overview of a text before reading it in-depth. It allows you to activate prior knowledge and set expectations for the content.

When previewing, skim to find and focus on these parts:

- Title, headings, and subheadings
- Introduction and conclusion
- Visual aids like graphs, charts, and images
- Key terms and definitions

During reading

Active reading

Active reading means engaging with the text, rather than passively reading. This helps you stay focused and better comprehend the material. Think of the act of reading as a conversation between the author and you. Some active reading strategies include the following:

- Underlining or highlighting key ideas and supporting details
- Taking notes in the margins or on a separate sheet
- Asking questions about the content as you read

- Making connections between the text and your own experiences or prior knowledge

Summarizing

Summarizing involves restating the main ideas and key points of a text in your own words. Summarizing reinforces your understanding and helps you remember the most important information. When summarizing:

- Identify the central theme or argument
- Outline the key supporting points
- Avoid including minor details or examples
- Paraphrase rather than quoting as much as possible

After reading

Reviewing the text after reading is crucial for solidifying your comprehension. This helps cement the information in your memory and prepares you for discussions or assessments. When reviewing:

- Revisit your notes, highlights, and summaries
- Reflect on what you learned and how it connects to your prior knowledge
- Identify any remaining questions or areas of confusion

SQ3R: a method for systematically applying reading strategies

 Notice this!

English instructors and textbooks have created many useful methods to systematically apply reading strategies before, during, and after you read. One of these is called the **SQ3R** Method. SQ3R stands for five **sequential** techniques you should use to read a book: **S**urvey, **Q**uestion, **R**ead, **R**ecite and **R**evue.

Table 2.6.1 explains more about each step.

Step	Description
S: Survey	Scan the entire assignment to get an overview of the material. Read the headings to see the major points. Read the introductory paragraphs and the summary at the end of the chapter. Do not forget to look at the tables, pictures, etc. Remember, you are scanning the material and not actually reading every sentence.
Q: Question	Make questions that can be answered during the reading of the material. This will give a purpose to your reading. Take a heading and turn it into a question. For example, if a heading in a chapter about Cell Division is in your biology text, make a question by turning the title

Step	Description
	around: “How does cell division occur?” or “How many steps are involved in cell division?”
R: Read	Now you read the material trying to find answers to your questions. This is a careful reading, line by line. You may want to take notes or make flashcards.
R: Recite	As you read, look away from your book and notes and try to answer your questions. This checks your learning and helps put that information in your memory.
R: Review	To check your memory, scan portions of the material or your notes to verify your answers. Review the material and note the main

Step	Description
	points under each heading. This review step helps you retain the material.

Check your knowledge

? Try this!

Drag the words into the correct boxes

The purpose of the
 [] step in
 the SQ3R method is to
 gain an []
 of the main concepts in
 the chapter. This will help
 you to identify main ideas
 and focus your reading.
 The [] step
 asks you to create
 questions that you will

overview

recite

review

survey

question

answer

purpose

read

intervals

Now use these skills

Apply this!

Now that you’ve learned about the SQ3R method (Survey, Question, Read, Recite, Review), let’s apply it to the text below. Follow the steps outlined in the activity to practice this effective reading strategy.

Here is the text, which is an **excerpt** from an article by Christina Pazzanese in the *Harvard Gazette*. In this excerpt,

Pazzanese is quoting Dr. Emily Carter from the Center for Ethical AI Studies.

"The rapid advancement of **artificial intelligence** (AI) technologies has raised significant ethical concerns in various fields, including healthcare, education, and criminal justice. For instance, in healthcare AI helps doctors find diseases and suggest treatments. However, if the data used to teach AI has biases, some patients may not get fair treatment. Similarly, in education, AI tools can help personalize learning. But, if these tools are not designed carefully, they may make existing problems worse. Finally, in criminal justice, some AI systems predict crime but can harm communities already facing unfair treatment. To solve these ethical issues, we need help from many different experts, including technology experts, ethicists, lawmakers, and the communities affected."

Step 1. Survey

Skim the excerpt. Look for headings, bolded words, or key phrases. Since this is a short excerpt, focus on identifying the main topic and the three fields discussed.

What is the main topic?

Click here to see the answer

AI and ethical concerns

What are the three fields discussed?

Click here to see the answer

healthcare, education, and criminal justice

Step 2. Question

Turn the main ideas into questions. What questions can you think of that the text answers?

Click here to see possible questions

- What industries are being transformed by AI?
- What are the potential benefits of AI according to the article?
- What ethical concerns arise from the increasing use of AI in decision-making?

Step 3. Read

Here are some key points that answer the example questions above:

Click here to see possible answers

- Industries Transformed: AI is essential in health care, banking, retail, and manufacturing.
- Potential Benefits: AI can improve efficiency, reduce costs, and accelerate research and development.
- Ethical Concerns: There are worries that AI systems may cause societal harm and lack the necessary oversight to prevent biases.

Step 4. Recite

Without looking at the text, try to answer out loud the questions you created in Step 2.

Step 5: Review

Go back to the text and check your answers. Did you miss any important details? Reflect on the main ideas and how they connect to the broader topic of AI ethics.

Works Cited

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7: Participating in Class Discussions



Figure 7.1: "Guide to Engaging in Class Discussions" by Nicole Otero. CC-0

Tips for joining a class discussion with confidence

Speaking up and responding to classmates is often required in U.S. college classrooms, and may be part of your grade for the class. Participating in class discussions is a valuable skill that enhances your learning experience and helps you engage with your peers, your instructors, and the material. However, it can be intimidating, so it is important to build your confidence and prepare. Follow these tips to help you prepare for, engage during, and reflect after class discussion.

Before class:

- **Building your Confidence:** The most important thing is to remember that making mistakes is part of the learning process. Teachers and classmates are usually supportive, so don't be afraid to try to use the target language. Creating an environment where it's okay to fail can help reduce anxiety.
- **Prepare:** Come to class ready for success. Read the assigned materials thoroughly and take notes on key points to understand the topic. Review the discussion topic beforehand and prepare some key points or phrases you might want to use. In addition, build your vocabulary and grammar knowledge related to common discussion topics. This will help you feel more prepared and reduce hesitation when speaking.
- **Engage with the Content:** Think about questions or comments you might have regarding the readings. Use the SQ3R approach or other reading and note-taking methods ahead of time to spark discussion in class.
- **Research:** Look for additional resources or articles (including in your first language) that relate to the topic.

During class:

- **Listen Actively:** Listen to what others are saying; avoid distractions and do not look at your phone.
- **Take Notes:** Jot down key points or ideas that resonate with you. Instead of trying to write down everything, focus on capturing the main ideas, important terms, and any examples provided. This will make your notes more concise and relevant.
- If you do partner or group work, practice saying your ideas to your partner(s) so it's not the first time if you get called on to say them in front of the whole class.

Participating in the discussion:

- **When your *instructor asks a question to the class*:**
 - Raise your hand and make eye contact, but don't call out or wave your hand all around trying to catch their attention.
 - Before speaking, take a moment to gather your thoughts and take a deep breath. Don't just blurt it out! Make sure to speak calmly and clearly. The seconds passing seem longer to you than to anyone else.
- **When your *instructor asks you a question directly*:**
 - Be honest and admit it if you don't know the answer or are not sure. Don't try to fake it or make excuses. With a question that involves a reasoned opinion more than a fact, it's fine to explain why you haven't decided yet, such as when weighing two opposing ideas or actions; your comment may stimulate further discussion.
 - Organize your thoughts to give a sufficient answer. Instructors seldom want a yes or no answer. Give your answer and provide reasons or evidence in support.
- **When you want to ask the instructor a question:**
 - Don't ever feel a question is "stupid." If you have been paying attention in class and have done the reading and you still don't understand something, you have every right to ask. It's likely that other students have the same question and will be happy you were brave enough to ask it for all of you.
 - Ask at the appropriate time. Don't interrupt the instructor or jump ahead and ask a question about something the instructor may be starting to explain. Wait for a natural pause and a good moment to ask. On the other hand, unless the instructor asks students to hold all questions until the end of class, don't let too much time go by, or you may forget the question or its relevance to the topic.
- Use the expressions in [Table 2.4.1 Sentence Starters for Class Discussions](#) to help you participate in the discussion.

You can ask for clarification, build on others' ideas, give examples, etc. These phrases might seem a little stiff or formal at first, like you are acting in a play, but they will help you sound polite and help everyone move the discussion along.

After class:

- **Reflect on the Discussion:** Think about what went well and what could be improved in future discussions.
- **Follow Up on Your Questions:** Research or ask about any questions you still have.
- **Connect with Peers:** Engage with classmates to discuss thoughts or ideas further.
- **Practice Speaking:** Consider ways to articulate your thoughts more clearly next time.
- **Foster a Growth Mindset & Embrace Challenges:** View each discussion as an opportunity to grow rather than a test of your abilities. Acknowledge that improvement comes with practice and experience. Recognize and celebrate your successes, no matter how small. This positive reinforcement can motivate you to continue participating actively.

Academic conversational moves

Table 2.4.1 provides some helpful language for academic conversational "moves" - you can think of them as moves in a cooperative game designed for everyone to win:

Table 2.4.1 Sentence Starters for Class Discussions

Conversational Move/ Language Function	Possible Sentence Starters	Notes
State an idea or say your opinion	• I believe ... • One way to look at this is... • It seems like... • Based on ..., I think... • Do you think it's possible that? • What if we ...	Using these "hedging" phrases actually makes you sound more confident in your idea. You're showing that you have thought carefully and are aware that not everyone may agree with your point, but that you are solid in your position.
Get started when discussing a text	• One thing that struck me was... • I didn't really understand the part where they say... • I was surprised by... • On page..., where they talk about ..., I was wondering... • You know the part where she's explaining ...? Why do you think she...? • When he says..., it makes it seem like... • This part reminds me of/seems connected to... [previous class concept or something else in the book/your lives]	Make sure your classmates know which part of the text you are referencing, with page numbers, paragraph numbers, or more context as needed.
Support your idea	• I think an example of this is ... • For instance, ...	Be as specific as possible in your support. If you

Conversational Move/ Language Function	Possible Sentence Starters	Notes
	- According to... - In paragraph..., the author says... - When they're talking about ..., they say... - There's evidence for this at the top of page ..., when they are talking about ...	are talking about a written text, say the page or paragraph number so others can easily find the same part.
Make connections, or elaborate on someone else's idea	- Like ... was saying before, ... - This is important because ... - When you said ..., it reminded me of ... - Your idea also makes me think of ... - To build on ...'s point, ... - I want to expand on your point about ... - I want to follow up on ___'s idea ... - Another example I thought of is ...	If possible, say the person's name. It's very important not to repeat the same thing someone else has already said without connecting your idea, because then it looks like you are taking credit for their idea or were not listening.
Paraphrase, clarify, or synthesize	- In other words, ... - Let me see if I understand you ... - So essentially, you are saying ... - I hear you saying that ... - I think it means ... - The main theme/point seems to be ... - The evidence seems to suggest	These conversational moves help you and everyone else make sure you understand.

Conversational Move/ Language Function	Possible Sentence Starters	Notes
	that ...	
Ask questions	- What does ... mean? - What do you mean when you say ...? - Can you explain what you mean about ...? - What do you think about ...? - Can you tell me more about ...? - Is this similar to ...?	English question grammar is one of the last skills English learners perfect, even when they are very fluent. It's really complicated! Here is a brief Question Grammar Review if you need to check your question structure.
Agree with an idea	- I agree with your point because... - Your idea makes sense because ... - I think you make a good point that ... - My perspective is similar to ___'s ...	When you agree, you need to do more than the verbal equivalent of hitting a "like" button: add a reason or an example of your own to the other person's idea.
Challenge or disagree with an idea	- Another perspective is that ... - Another way to look at this is ... - I see this differently because ... - In my experience, it's more complicated, because... - Although you make a good point about ..., I think ... because ... - I see what you're saying about..., but...	It may feel unfamiliar to do this in class, especially if you are not an expert in the subject matter, but it's an expected activity in U.S. classroom culture, and you will get better at doing it carefully to build understanding rather than offending people.

Conversational Move/ Language Function	Possible Sentence Starters	Notes
	- I'd like to push back a little on the idea that... - I'm not sure the author means.../we should/it's 100% true that...	
Report from a small group to the whole class	- We agreed that... - We focused on... - We thought the most important ... was... - Most of us thought... - We came to the conclusion that... - One interesting point ... made was that... - We had different ideas. ... thought..., but ... thought... ...brought up an interesting question: ...	Especially if several groups are reporting out, your classmates will all appreciate your effort to be concise - don't give a long speech repeating everything that was said in the small group. If you are not the first group to report out, remember to use the conversational moves above to connect, agree, etc.
Help democratize/redirect the group conversation	- Excuse me, I don't think ... was finished... - That sounds similar to what ... said before ... - Can I please interrupt for a moment? - We haven't heard from ... yet... ..., would you like to add anything? - Can we pause for a second? I wanted to hear more about... - Maybe we should get back to ...	Try to notice: Am I speaking up? Am I talking over other people? Is someone else getting left out? Is our group still on task? The goal is not for one person to perform their knowledge, but for everyone to build meaning together. Listening is just as important - or more important - than talking. A

Conversational Move/ Language Function	Possible Sentence Starters	Notes
	I think we're supposed to...	few seconds of silence can be awkward, but don't always rush to fill it.
Buy time/get help	- I'm sorry, can you repeat the question/clarify our task/define...? - That's a good question. Let me look at my notes for a minute. - Can you please come back to me? - I need a moment to collect my thoughts. - I didn't understand what [Professor] wants us to do. Can you explain it?	Sometimes it feels like you are on stage with bright lights shining on you in a class where you have to talk. It's OK to take a breath. If you missed something, chances are good that other students also missed it and are too embarrassed to say anything. These phrases show you are actively participating, and other students will be relieved that you asked.

Check your knowledge

? Try this!

Study the phrases in **Table 2.4.1 Sentence Starters for Class Discussions** above. Decide which phrases the participants in the dialogue below might use to connect and advance their ideas. There are many possible right answers.

Professor Chen: Good morning, class! Today, let's discuss the article we read about possible climate change solutions. Yuka, what do you think were the author's best ideas?

Yuka: Transitioning to renewable energy sources! _____, solar and wind power are clean and reduce reliance on fossil fuels.

Alex: _____. We should also enforce stricter regulations to reduce the environmental impact.

Professor Chen: Great ideas! What challenges might we face in implementing these solutions?

Yuka: _____ the initial cost could be a challenge, but the long-term benefits outweigh it.

Professor Chen: _____. Well done, both of you!

? Try this!

Read each statement below and decide whether it is **true** or **false** based on the tips and strategies above.

1. To avoid having to answer a question in class when you don't know the answer, sit in the back row and avoid making eye contact with the instructor.

Click here to see the answer

false

2. If you haven't finished a reading assignment before coming to a lecture class, bring the book along and try to complete the reading during the lecture.

Click here to see the answer

false

3. Although it is OK to disagree with something in your textbook, never disagree with something the instructor says in a lecture.

Click here to see the answer

false

4. If you are asked a question but don't know the answer, it's best to be honest and admit it.

Click here to see the answer

true

5. Because you don't want your instructor to form a poor impression of you, wait a week or two into the term before starting to ask questions in class.

Click here to see the answer

false

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9: Working in Teams



Figure 9.1: "Students working as a team." (CC-0; via [Pixabay.com](https://www.pixabay.com))

Why is teamwork important?

Successfully collaborating with other students, as in Figure 2.9.1, is an essential part of your U.S. academic journey. Part of your college experience will require you to learn how to work with others to solve complex problems, and these skills will help you to engage in learning and in your future career. The skills you will learn through collaboration include time management skills, problem-solving skills, and how to work with others effectively. Some students may enjoy working in teams, and others may find it challenging, but collaboration is a vital skill in both academic and professional settings.

Key principles of effective teamwork



Figure 9.1: "Effective Teamwork" CC-0 by Nicole Otero

• Clear Communication

- **Open Dialogue:** Encourage open discussions where all team members feel comfortable sharing ideas and opinions. Decision-making and problem-solving can be more effective when performed in a diverse team environment. It's important to be aware of cultural as well as individual differences that might come up among team members.

Notice this!

Key Cultural Differences in a Team

Direct versus indirect communication

Some cultures are very direct and explicit in their communication, while others are more indirect and ask questions rather than pointing out problems. This difference can cause conflict because, at the extreme, the direct style may be considered offensive by some, while the indirect style may be perceived as unproductive and passive-aggressive in team interactions.

Accents and fluency

When team members don't speak the same language, there may be one language that dominates the group interaction, and those who don't speak it may feel left out. The speakers of the primary language may feel that those members don't contribute as much or are less competent.

Conflicting decision-making norms

Different cultures make decisions differently, and some will apply a great deal of analysis and preparation beforehand. Those cultures that make decisions more quickly (and need just enough information to make a decision) may be frustrated with the slow response and relatively longer thought process.

- **Active Listening:** Practice active listening by paying attention to others and acknowledging their contributions. Some active listening tips include head nodding and asking clarifying questions.
- **Using Technology:** Utilize communication tools (like group chats, forums, or video calls) to stay connected.
- **Defined Roles and Responsibilities**
 - **Assign Roles:** Clearly define each team member's role.

- **Set Expectations:** Establish expectations/responsibilities for each role to ensure accountability and productivity. See the example below.

Notice This!

Example Set of Roles and Responsibilities

Group Goal: Research the history of one immigrant group in Hawai'i and their contributions to the local culture and language. Also, identify what services are currently provided for this group in their first language. Create a Google Slides presentation with your group to teach your classmates about your research.

Example set of roles and responsibilities in a group project

Role

Role

Role

Role

Role	Responsibilities	Example Task
Researchers	Group Member #1 Topic 1: Identify the history of the group's immigration to Hawai'i.	Use the provided sources and research articles to identify the history of the group's immigration to Hawai'i.
	Group Member #2 Topic 2: Identify what services are currently provided for this group in their first language.	Use the provided sources and research articles to identify what services are currently provided for this group in their first language.
	Group Member #3 Topic 3: Identify the influence this group has on local culture and language in Hawai'i.	Use the provided sources and research articles to identify the influence this group has on local culture and language in Hawai'i.
Writers	All Members: Organize your research findings and write the main sections of the project.	Design a Google Slides presentation that summarizes the project's findings. Make sure to include visuals and proper citations.
Presenters	All Members: Each member should practice and deliver their part of the presentation with clarity.	Practice and deliver the presentation.
Project	Manage the	Create a

Role	Responsibilities	Example Task
Coordinator	project's timeline; schedule meetings, take notes, and maintain communication among group members.	timeline with deadlines for each part of the project and send reminders to the team.

- **Regular Check-Ins:** Schedule regular meetings to assess the group's progress. Set agendas for meetings and have someone take notes to record decisions that are made. See the example below.

Notice This!

Meeting Documents: Agendas and Minutes

What happens at team meetings should be planned and recorded for future reference. **Agendas** and **Minutes** are documents that do this. A meeting also should have a person who keeps things on track and a recorder who records what happened and what decisions were made. The agenda is the plan for what you want to discuss and accomplish at the meeting. It is usually made up of a list of items, sometimes with a time frame for each item.

Sample Agenda

ESOL 94 Team Meeting Agenda

Date:

Place and time:

Members:

Updates from each team member (progress) (5 min each)

Develop a work plan for the upcoming week (15 min)

Determine next meeting time (5 min)

Next meeting: next Thursday, Feb 21, after class

Excellent progress during the meeting.

Meeting adjourned at 4:00

Task	Who will do it?
1. Research Topic #1	Julian
2. Research Topic #2	Mimi
3. Research Topic #3	Hideki

Notes-follow up on the agenda by recording what decisions were made and what important topics were discussed. One person is responsible for recording the events of the meeting.

Sample Minutes

ESOL 94 Team Meeting Minutes

Thursday Feb, 15, 2025

The Cafeteria, 3:30-4:00

Present: Julian, Mimi, Hideki

All team members have completed last week's work plan (Joe emailed a report, as she is sick)

In the coming week, we plan to complete the following:

Fostering a Positive Team Environment

- **Encourage Inclusivity:** Promote an inclusive atmosphere where everyone's voice is valued. Treat all team members with respect and understanding.

Notice This!

Ways to Promote Positive Dialogue

Strategy	Example Language
Encouragement	Acknowledge and appreciate each other's ideas (e.g., "I really loved your idea...").
Collaboration	Express willingness to work together (e.g., "I can help with...").
Constructive Suggestions	Offer ideas that build on others' contributions (e.g., "Maybe we could also look into...").

Positive Tone

Maintain an upbeat and enthusiastic attitude throughout the dialogue (e.g., "I'm excited to see how everything comes together!").

- **Manage Conflicts:** If you have a conflict within your group, remember that communication is key! See the different conflict management strategies below and example language to use with each strategy.

Notice This!

Ways To Manage Conflict

Strategy	Example Language
Acknowledge the Conflict	"It seems like we have different perspectives on this issue. Let's take a moment to understand everyone's point of view."
Encourage Open Communication	"Let's make sure everyone has a chance to speak. What are your thoughts on this, [Name]?"
Use Collaborative Language	"How can we combine our ideas to come up with a solution that works for everyone?"
Reframe Negative Statements	Instead of: "Your idea won't work.", Say: "I see where you're coming from, but I think there might be some challenges. How can we address those?" Instead of: "You're not listening to me.", Say: "I feel like my perspective hasn't been fully understood. Can I explain it again?"

Check your knowledge

? Try this!

Instructions: Choose the best response for each scenario related to promoting a positive team environment and managing conflicts.

1. Your team is discussing a new project, and you notice that one member hasn't spoken up. What is the best way to encourage inclusivity?

- A) "I really value everyone's input. [Name], what do you think about this?"
- B) "I believe we have enough ideas already."

Click here to see the answer

A. "I really value everyone's input. [Name], what do you think about this?"

2. During a brainstorming session, a colleague shares a great idea. How should you respond to promote positive dialogue?

- A) "I really loved your idea! It could lead to something amazing!"
- B) "Let's not get too excited; it might not work."

Click here to see the answer

A. "I really loved your idea! It could lead to something amazing!"

3. You sense tension in the group after a disagreement. What is the best approach to acknowledge the conflict?

- A) "Let's just move on; it's not a big deal."
- B) "It seems like we have different perspectives on this issue. Let's take a moment to understand everyone's point of view."

Click here to see the answer

B. "It seems like we have different perspectives on this issue. Let's take a moment to understand everyone's point of view."

Now use these skills

Apply this!

Exercise

Reflect on your previous teamwork experience.

Think of a time when you had to work with others to produce something such as a design, poster, presentation, document, *etc.* Briefly describe what the task was and consider the following questions:

1. What was the team's overall goal?
2. What was your role within the group?
3. How were the expectations for each role within the group?
4. How well did your group communicate?
5. Was the outcome successful?
6. How would you rate your overall experience and why?

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10: Delivering Presentations

Preparing your presentation



Figure 10.1: "Woman writing on the whiteboard while delivering a presentation." (CC-0; via Pixabay.com)

You will likely be asked to deliver presentations in your college courses, as illustrated in Figure 2.10.1, and good preparation is key to building confidence and delivering a successful presentation. Good preparation means you understand what you want to say and how you want to say it.

- **Understand Your Topic:** Make sure you know the main points you want to share and why they are important. Example: If your presentation is about climate change, your main points could be causes, effects, and solutions.
- **Organize Your Ideas:** Use a clear structure. Just as an academic essay requires a specific structure, an effective presentation should also include a beginning, middle, and end.

ORAL PRESENTATION STRUCTURE



Figure 10.1: Oral Presentation Structure

Infographic. (CC-0 by Nicole Otero)

Oral Presentation Structure

Introduction: Start with a greeting and introduce your topic. Just as in an academic essay, it can be useful to use a hook strategy like asking a question or using a famous quote to engage your audience from the start. See the hook strategies below.

Table 2.10.1 Presentation Hook Strategies

Hook Strategy	Example
Ask a rhetorical question or a real question for the audience, with or without an image	Do you use your phone every morning before getting out of bed? Raise your hand if you looked at your phone before getting out of bed this morning. (Show a picture of a traffic jam.) What do you think causes this problem in big cities?
Use an interesting fact or statistic	Did you know that people spend over 6 hours a day using digital media?
Tell a short personal anecdote	Last week, I lost my phone for one day. I felt lost, but I also learned something important.
Use a famous quote	Walt Disney once said, "If you can dream it, you can do it." Today I will talk about following your dreams.

Body: Explain your main points in detail and present evidence. Remember to use transitions to move from one point to another and enable your presentation to flow smoothly. (Examples: "First, I will talk about...", "Another important point is...", "A good example of this is...", "As a result, ...", "To summarize, ...")

Conclusion: Summarize your points, leave the audience with a final message, and thank your audience. Some options for final messages:

- End with a powerful quote connected to your topic: "To end, I'll share a quote from..."
- Call to action- encourage your audience to do something: "Now it's your turn to..." "Let's take action by..." "After you leave this room today..."
- Give a final thought or reflection and leave the audience with something to think about: "Think about how this affects your life..."
- **Useful expressions for delivering a presentation:** Table 2.10.2 provides some helpful language:

Table 2.10.2 Useful Expressions for a Presentation

Presentation parts	Useful expressions for each part
Introduction	- After the hook, some ways to transition to the topic: - This presentation will investigate/ examine/ identify - My partner and I/ My group will discuss ... - Today, I/ we will tell you about... - Some ways to transition to the outline/preview of the presentation: - Before discussing _____, I would like to ... - There are # main points I'd like to discuss today, which are ... - The effects of ... will be shown by ...
Body	Some ways to introduce a main point: - A major _____ is ... - A significant _____ is ... - Firstly, let's look at... - This point is important because... - According to recent studies... - Now, let's move on to the next point... - To illustrate this, I would like to show you... - In summary of this section... Some ways to introduce an example: - This is illustrated by... - An example of this is ... - Take for example... - Let's look at some ways this works:... - One place we see this pattern is... Some ways to start explaining a visual: - Now, I'll show you ... - As you can see here ... - The diagram indicates ...
Conclusion	Some ways to lead into the conclusion: - To conclude, I would like to summarize the key points. - Thank you for your attention, and I hope you found this presentation helpful. - If you have any questions, I would be happy to answer them. - In closing, remember that... - I appreciate your time and interest in this topic.

- **Practice Pronunciation:** Identify key words as well as any difficult words in your presentation and practice saying them. You can use tools like Google Translate or YouGlish to hear correct pronunciations.

Delivering Your Presentation

- **Start Confidently:** Your body language contributes to the effectiveness of your presentation. The nonverbal content of a presentation is just as important as the verbal delivery. A person's body language, including eye contact, facial expressions, posture, gestures, and movement, communicates a powerful message to an audience before any words are spoken.
- **Eye Contact:** Maintaining eye contact is important when delivering a presentation. If you are speaking to a very large group, it may be difficult to make eye contact with each individual. Instead, focus on a smaller group or one row of people at a time. Look in their direction for a few seconds and then shift your gaze to another small group in the room. If direct eye contact is uncomfortable for you, try looking at people's foreheads.
- **Posture:** While eye contact establishes a connection with your audience, your posture establishes your confidence. Stand straight and tall with your head held high to project confidence and authority.
- **Movement and Gestures:** The final piece of body language that helps tie your presentation together is your use of gestures and movement. A speaker who barely moves may come across as lacking energy and emotion. Excessive movement and gestures, on the other hand, are distracting. Strive for balance. A little movement can do a lot to help you connect with your audience and add energy to your presentation. Try stepping forward toward your audience at key moments where you really want to establish that personal connection. Consider where you

might use gestures such as pointing, holding up your hand, or moving your hands for emphasis. Avoid putting your hands in your pockets or clapping them in front of or behind you.



Figure 10.2: "Meeting, Conference, Teamwork Image." Via Pixabay, Licensed CC-0.

Table 2.10.3 provides some common and effective gestures used when delivering presentations:

Types of gestures for public speaking

Type of Gesture	Examples & Purpose
Hand and Arm Gestures	- Open Palms – Signals honesty, openness, and trust - Hand Over Heart – Conveys sincerity or emotion - Counting on Fingers – Helps organize points visually (e.g., "There are three reasons...") - Framing with Hands – Emphasizes a concept or sets boundaries around a point
Facial Expressions	- Smiling – Builds rapport, warmth, and approachability - Raised Eyebrows – Indicates surprise or poses a question - Nodding – Encourages audience engagement and signals agreement
Posture and Body Movement	- Standing Tall – Projects confidence and readiness - Stepping Forward – Shows emphasis or transition to a key point - Leaning Slightly In – Creates intimacy or focus
Gestures to Avoid	- Fidgeting with hands or objects – Distracting and reduces credibility - Crossed Arms – May seem closed-off or defensive - Hands in Pockets – Can look casual or unprepared - Overusing Gestures – May distract from your message

More presentation tips

- Use Simple and Clear Language:**
 - Avoid long or complex sentences.
 - Don't speak too fast. Pause briefly after finishing a sentence to give your audience time to understand.
- Use Visual Aids:** Use slides, charts, or images to support your message. Example: Add a graph showing the growth of solar energy use over the years. Here are some tips for effective and professional graphic design:
 - Use a font and size that is appropriate - usually 20+.
 - Notice the position of images and text. Are they overlapping? Is your slide too crowded? Try duplicating the slide and putting half the content on each one, leaving the heading and/or images in place.
 - Avoid distracting colors and make sure colors are in contrast with each other.
 - Pick effects and visuals that are stimulating and pleasing to the eye, but don't make animations too distracting.
- Engage the Audience:**
 - Ask questions to keep the audience involved at any time during the presentation.
 - Example: "How many of you think renewable energy is the future? Raise your hands!" "How many of you bring a reusable water bottle with you every day?"

Online Presentations: Tips for Success

Online presentations are different from in-person presentations. Here's how to make them work:

- Test your microphone, camera, and internet connection before the presentation.
- Instead of looking at the screen, look at your webcam to make eye contact with your audience.
- Internet delays can make it harder for your audience to follow. Speak slowly, and pause after each main point.
- Keep slides simple with minimal text.
- Use tools like polls, chat boxes, or Q&A features to interact with your audience.

Here is a short video from the University of Melbourne in Australia that expands on some of these tips:

Check your understanding:

? Try this!

Choose the correct answer for each question.

- What is the purpose of the introduction in a presentation?
 - To provide detailed information
 - To engage the audience and outline the topic
 - To summarize the presentation

Click here to see the answer

- To engage the audience and outline the topic

- Which phrase is commonly used to transition to the next point?
 - "In conclusion..."
 - "Now, let's move on to..."
 - "Thank you for your attention."

Click here to see the answer

- "Now, let's move on to..."

What should you do at the end of your presentation?

- Leave the stage immediately
- Ask the audience if they have questions
- Start a new topic

Click here to see the answer

- Ask the audience if they have questions

Now use your knowledge:

Apply this!

If you have not yet rehearsed in front of an audience, now is the time. Ask a peer (or a small group of people) to observe your presentation, provide a question-and-answer session, and have your audience provide feedback on the following:

- The overall quality of your content (clarity, organization, level of detail)
- The effectiveness of your visual aids
- Your vocal delivery (resonance, enunciation, volume, pitch, pace, and tone)
- The effectiveness of your body language (eye contact, facial expressions, posture, movement, and gestures)
- Your response to questions the audience posed during the question-and-answer session

Use your audience's feedback to make any final adjustments to your presentation. For example, could you clarify your presentation to reduce the number of questions—or enhance the quality of the questions—the audience asked during the question-and-answer session?

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11: Answering Test Questions

How can I succeed on academic tests?



Figure 11.1: "Students re taking a test in a classroom" Photo by [Fajar Herlambang STUDIO](#) on [Unsplash](#)

Answering test questions effectively is important for showcasing your understanding of class materials. Throughout your academic journey, just like the students pictures in Figure 2.11.1, you will be required to take exams that use a variety of question types to test your knowledge. All tests are designed to determine how much you know about a particular subject at a particular point in time. However, you should be aware of the differences in the types of tests because this will help guide how you prepare for them. Two general types of tests are based on their objectives, or how they are intended to be used: formative assessments and summative assessments.

- **Formative assessments** include quizzes, unit tests, pop quizzes, and review quizzes.
 - Their main objective is to make sure you know the fundamental material before moving on to more challenging topics.
 - Because these quizzes usually don't count much toward your final grade, many students think they are not very important. In fact, these quizzes are very important, particularly to you; they can help you to identify what you know and what you still need to learn to be successful in the course and in applying the material.
 - A poor result on a quiz may not negatively affect your final grade much, but learning from its results and correcting your mistakes will affect your final grade when you take midterms and finals!
- **Summative assessments** include midterms and finals.
 - These are used by the instructor to determine if you are mastering a large portion of the material, and as such, they usually carry a heavy weight toward your final grade for the course.

- Because of this, they often result in high levels of test anxiety and long study periods.

In addition to this classification by objective, tests can also be grouped into various categories based on how they are delivered. Each type has its own particular strategies.

- **Paper tests** are still the most common type of test, requiring students to write answers on the test pages or in a separate test booklet. They are typically used for in-class tests. Neatness and good grammar count, even if it's not an English exam.
- **Open-book tests** allow the student to consult their notes, textbook, or both while taking the exam. Instructors often give this type of test when they are more interested in seeing your thoughts and critical thinking than your memorization skills.
- **Take-home tests** are like open-book tests, except you have the luxury of time on your side. Make sure you submit the exam on time. Know what the instructor's expectations are about the content of your answers.
- **Online tests** are most commonly used for formative assessments, although they are starting to find their way into high-stakes exams. With online tests, be sure you understand the testing software. Find out if you will be allowed to move freely between test sections to go back and check your work or to complete questions you might have skipped. Some testing software does not allow you to return to sections once they are "submitted."
- **Presentations and oral tests** are the most complete means for instructors to evaluate students' mastery of material because the evaluation is highly interactive. Make sure you practice your presentation many times with and without an audience.

Strategies for answering test questions

- **Read the instructions carefully**
 - Ensure you understand the question before answering. If the question says "give two reasons," don't give just one.
 - Make sure you answer all parts of the question. Often, there will be more than one criterion to answer.
- **Manage your time**
 - Use your time wisely. If the test has 30 questions in 60 minutes, spend no more than 2 minutes per question. Save time at the end to review your answers.
 - If you don't know an answer, skip it and return to it later.
- **Look for key words**
 - Look for key terms, verbs, or instructions in the question, such as "explain," "describe," "compare," or "list."

- Example:
 - Question: Describe the process of evaporation.
 - Key Word: "Describe" – You need to explain the process step by step, not just define it.
- Table 2.11.1 defines some common verbs used in question prompts.

Table 2.11.1: Verbs often used in test questions

Objective Verb	Definition
Analyze	Examine and interpret the themes or elements of a text or topic.
Describe	Show what a topic, character, problem, etc. is like by giving specific, often sensory details.
Evaluate	Assess the strengths and weaknesses of arguments or ideas presented in the discussion.
Compare and Contrast	Identify similarities and differences between characters, themes, or concepts.
Summarize	Tell only the thesis and main points in your own words, citing the author.
Argue	Build and defend a position on a controversial issue, engaging with opposing viewpoints.

• Practice Proper Writing Skills

- Avoid sentence fragments or run-on sentences.
- Check for common grammatical errors such as subject-verb agreement, plural/singular nouns, and word forms.
- Make sure to check spelling and punctuation errors.

Types of test questions

Notice this!

We usually call test items "questions," but sometimes they are called "prompts," especially if they are not literally phrased as a question. Examples: all of these might be interchangeably called "questions" or "prompts":

- Give 3 reasons for your position.
- Which transportation priorities should local governments prioritize?
- Describe the Krebs cycle.

- What are the most important barriers to housing development in cities?

- **Multiple-Choice Questions:** These questions list possible answers (usually 3–5), and only one answer is correct.

- Example: What is the capital of France?

- A. Madrid
- B. Berlin
- C. Paris

- **Tips for answering multiple-choice questions:**

- Look for keywords in the question and match them to the options.
- Make sure to read all the options before choosing an answer.
- Even when you are confident in your first choice, another option might be a better choice.
- If you are unsure of the correct answer, narrow down your choices by using the elimination strategy and crossing out answers that are clearly incorrect.

- **True/False Questions:** These questions provide a statement that students must identify as true (yes) or false (no), often abbreviated "T/F."

- Example: Hawaii has no native species of birds. (T/F). Answer: F (False). Hawaii is home to many native bird species, such as the Hawaiian Honeycreeper and the Hawaiian Goose (Nene).

- **Tips for answering True/False Questions:**

- Words like "always," "never," or "only" often make statements false because they are too absolute.
- Words like "usually" or "sometimes" are less restrictive and may indicate a true statement.
- Remember that if any part of the statement is false, the entire statement is false.

- **Short-Answer Questions:** These questions require a brief written response (usually a sentence or two).

- Example: Question: Why is coral reef conservation important in Hawaii? Answer: Coral reef conservation is important in Hawaii because these ecosystems support diverse marine life, protect coastlines from erosion, and contribute to the local economy through tourism and fishing.

- **Tips for answering short-answer questions:**

- Answer the question directly, but include key details.
- Avoid unnecessary words, but also ensure your response is complete.
- Make sure to use complete sentences. This demonstrates your command of grammar and helps you practice writing in English.

- **Essay Questions:** These questions require an extended written response, often several paragraphs.
 - Example: Essay Prompt: Discuss the effects of climate change on Hawaii's environment.
 - Example Answer (outline):
 - Introduction: Climate change poses significant threats to Hawaii's unique ecosystems and communities.
 - Body Paragraph 1: Rising sea levels threaten coastal areas and habitats.
 - Example: Many beaches in Hawaii are eroding due to rising sea levels, impacting tourism and local wildlife.
 - Body Paragraph 2: Changing rainfall patterns affect freshwater resources.
 - Example: Some regions are experiencing droughts, which impact agriculture and water supply.
 - Conclusion: Addressing climate change is crucial for preserving Hawaii's natural beauty and ensuring the well-being of its residents.
 - **Tips for answering essay questions:**
 - Use an outline to organize your main ideas. Include a clear introduction, body paragraphs with supporting arguments, and a conclusion.
 - Start with a strong thesis that summarizes your main point.
 - Use examples and details to support your arguments.
 - Use transition words to connect ideas:
 - For adding ideas: "Additionally," "Furthermore," "Moreover"
 - For contrasting ideas: "However," "On the other hand," "In contrast"
 - For concluding: "In conclusion," "To summarize," "Overall"

Now check your understanding:

? Try this!

Directions: Read each test question below. Make sure to follow the instructions for the question type.

1. Multiple-Choice Question: Which of the following best explains why students should read test instructions carefully?

- A. To finish the test quickly
- B. To ensure they answer every part of the question

C. To check their spelling and punctuation

Click here to see the answer

B

2. True/False Question: If a short-answer question includes the word "describe," you only need to list one fact.

Click here to see the answer

False

Directions: Identify the key verb(s) in each of the following prompts:

- Describe the role of volcanoes in shaping Hawaii's islands.
- Compare and contrast renewable and non-renewable energy sources.
- Summarize the main idea of today's lesson.
- Argue whether or not school uniforms should be required.

Click here to see the answers

Describe, Compare/Contrast, Summarize, Argue

Now use what you have learned:

Apply this!

Think of a topic you are studying in one of your classes. Choose three types of test questions (e.g., multiple-choice, short answer, essay) and write your own questions using the academic verbs from Table 2.11.1 above. Trade with a classmate and evaluate each other's questions. Then write the answers.

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